an MEA representative was part of the delegation, the signing of an agreement at the military level was agreed to. The ninth round concluded on a positive note, with both sides agreeing to confirm the proposals at the earliest through the Hot Line.

On the home front, Isha was staying with us at Army House for her confinement, with the baby due in early February 2021. Isha and Simon had broken the good news earlier the previous year. As soon as Veena came to know of it, she dropped all plans of moving to Pune post-retirement. Her focus was now on Isha and the grandchild. Since 26 January was Republic Day, all offices had been shut down early on the 25th for security purposes, and I had returned home for lunch. Later in the day, Isha came to our room to say that she was feeling uncomfortable. We straightaway went to the Mayoom Hospital in Gurgaon, where Isha was going for her check-ups. After a quick check-up, the doctor felt that there was some foetal distress and that an immediate delivery was called for. We rang up Simon, who was still at school, it being a working day. Isha was wheeled into the OT, and even before Simon could reach, our grandchild, Arvin, was born. From the time Isha reported her discomfort to the birth was hardly two hours. It was the best Republic Day present ever, even better than my PVSM, which I had been awarded on the eve of Republic Day 2019.

While all this was going on, I was making regular visits to Leh and the forward areas to see for myself our deployment and infrastructure development in preparation for the forthcoming winter. Sometimes, I had to squeeze in these visits between other appointments. I was to leave for an official visit to South Korea in end-December, so I decided to visit the troops before Christmas. The schedule was so packed that the only free day was 23 December. We went early in the morning up to Leh, then by ALHs up to Tara Base and then up to Rechin La,

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